

‘Egyptian’. Each of the six codices mentioned above has a distinct conglomerate of variants; they are each rather different from all the others. Since they each have neither parents nor children (that we know of), they are individual productions, fabricated copies. We have no way of knowing what motivated each of the copyists who produced those fabricated copies. However, our ignorance on that point does not change the nature of those fabricated copies.

After I circulated a prior edition of this article, Dr. Michael C. Loehrer sent me a few thoughts about producing a ‘text-type’ without an archetype:

While we cannot *know* what motivated the copyists to fabricate variations into the text, we can surmise what motivated them from where they lived and what they believed. They lived in Egypt and they held Gnostic beliefs in a Greco-Roman world. In their world, mixture of beliefs demonstrated mutual respect and a willingness to promote peace; one of their highest ideals. Jews and Christians believed such mixture diluted or compromised absolute truth. Egyptian Gnostics attempted to improve an imperfect text. Jews and Christians believed they began with a perfect text. Consequently, Jews and Christians sought to make copies faithful to their exemplar. Egyptian Gnostics sought to improve their exemplar. Several lines of reasoning influenced the conclusions above:

1. In the Roman Empire there were no copyright laws, so as soon as a text was released to the public it was vulnerable to free alteration—anyone could change it.
2. Gnostic copyists introduced intentional changes because they believed they were improving an imperfect text (they assumed all texts were imperfect, because they were of human origin).
3. They did not believe that divine authorship and inerrancy were possible in a material world (perfection existed only in the immaterial world).
4. They believed they had special knowledge and therefore an obligation to attempt improvements.
5. They believed they were superior (academically and religiously) to the common people who passed along inferior copies before them.